

A LI'L CHEER Manish Sisodia (in black) with Sanjay Singh (left), Gopal Rai and Atishi at an AAP meeting a day after he got bail, Aug. 10

apparently got kickbacks of at least Rs 100 crore in 2022, which they used for the assembly election in Punjab (where it formed the government) and Goa. Some business interests in the alcohol industry allegedly paid this and more to AAP for the liquor policy to favour them.

ATTACK IS THE BEST DEFENCE

From Day 1, AAP has fought this case both politically as well as legally with a central strategy: attack is the best defence, questioning the very *causa causans* of the controversy. Its legal defence pulls up the necessity as well as the legality of the arrests and discredits the motivation of the prosecution's witnesses. In the lower courts, Kejriwal has openly charged that the agencies and the BJP coerced the witnesses. "Ultimately, punishment (conviction) will not happen. That is why the process is the punishment," Singhvi says.

The strategy may be working finally. Because following Kejriwal's interim bail and Sisodia's recent release, another accused, K. Kavitha, daughter of Bharat Rashtra Samithi leader and former chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao, also got bail on August 27 after five months. "We will fight it out legally and politically. I was put behind bars only because of politics," says Kavitha. In her bail hearing, the Supreme Court even rapped the investigating agencies for their lack of 'fairness'. "The prosecution has to be fair. You can't pick and choose [whom you want to prosecute]. Where is the fairness?" the SC bench headed by Justices B.R. Gavai and K.V. Viswanathan asked. In fact, citing the Sisodia ruling, the bench has said that bail is the rule, not an exception, even in PMLA cases.

With things looking up legally, AAP has decided to take the fight to its constituencies. 'Kejriwal *aayenge*' is its latest mobilisation drive on the ground. Sisodia is holding regular walks in various constituencies and telling people that now that he is out, it is just a matter of time before the Delhi CM is back too.

AAP is aware of its hyperlocal strength in Delhi. Even at the height of the liquor controversy, it scripted a

AAP STRATEGY

- **'Kejriwal *aayenge*' is the new mobilisation call on the ground. Sisodia, others hit campaign trail**
- **Leverage its 13 MPs (3 in LS and 10 in RS) to take fight to BJP in both Houses, keep contact with Oppn bloc**
- **Party to ensure zero defections from AAP ranks. Councillor Ram Chander, who joined BJP a few days back, returns**